

GRE-Style Verbal Reasoning Practice Set - Set 2

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This reader copy places all answer keys and explanations after the questions so you can work through the set before checking solutions.

Contents: 15 Reading Comprehension questions, 9 Text Completion questions, and 6 Sentence Equivalence questions.

Questions

Reading Comprehension

Passage 1

Researchers reconstructing ancient monsoon patterns sometimes analyze leaf waxes preserved in lake sediments. The hydrogen isotopes in these waxes can reflect rainfall, but the signal is not a simple rain gauge. Plants growing on different slopes may contribute waxes at different rates, and erosion can deliver older material to the lake during storms. A shift in isotope ratios, therefore, might indicate a change in precipitation, a change in which plants supplied the waxes, or a temporary increase in reworked sediments. Several paleoclimatologists now treat leaf-wax records as most persuasive when they align with independent pollen counts, shoreline evidence, and models of seasonal runoff. In their view, the proxy is valuable precisely because it raises testable questions rather than because it yields an isolated chronology.

rc-001. Which of the following best states the main point of the passage?

- A. Leaf-wax records are unreliable because storms can introduce older sediment into lake deposits.
- B. Leaf-wax isotope data can illuminate past rainfall, but they require corroboration and careful interpretation.
- C. Pollen counts and shoreline evidence are more precise indicators of ancient monsoon patterns than isotope records are.
- D. The chief value of leaf-wax analysis is that it can replace models of seasonal runoff.
- E. Researchers have largely abandoned lake sediments because their signals are too difficult to date.

rc-002. The paleoclimatologists mentioned in the passage would be most likely to challenge which of the following claims?

- A. A change in leaf-wax isotope ratios may suggest a change in ancient precipitation patterns.
- B. Different plant communities can affect the isotope signal preserved in lake sediments.
- C. A leaf-wax record is strongest when it agrees with independent lines of evidence.
- D. A single shift in isotope ratios can by itself establish the timing and cause of a monsoon change.
- E. Runoff models can help researchers evaluate sedimentary evidence from lakes.

rc-003. Based on the passage, which of the following are possible explanations for a shift in leaf-wax isotope ratios? Select all that apply.

- A. The amount or character of precipitation changed.
- B. The plants contributing waxes to the lake changed.

C. Storm-driven erosion temporarily delivered older material to the lake.

Passage 2

Historians of commerce once portrayed early merchant courts as practical institutions that simply applied shared customs. Recent work has complicated that portrait. Court records show merchants invoking custom, but they also reveal disputes over what the custom required and strategic efforts to present novel practices as ancient usage. Written judgments, moreover, often appeared only after litigants pressed for them, so the surviving archive may overrepresent conflicts in which rules were already unsettled. The courts were therefore neither informal markets for compromise nor modern bureaucracies enforcing a fixed code. They were arenas in which commercial norms were asserted, contested, and gradually stabilized.

rc-004. Which of the following best describes the passage's central claim about early merchant courts?

- A. They enforced a stable body of custom without allowing litigants to challenge its meaning.
- B. They were chiefly informal institutions whose records tell historians little about commercial norms.
- C. They helped shape commercial norms through disputes over customs that were not always settled in advance.
- D. They became modern bureaucracies once merchants began requesting written judgments.
- E. They encouraged merchants to abandon custom in favor of entirely novel practices.

rc-005. The passage implies that historians using written judgments from merchant courts should be cautious because those judgments may

- A. come disproportionately from cases in which the relevant customs were disputed.
- B. record only cases in which merchants had already abandoned commercial custom.
- C. prove that litigants never used strategic arguments about tradition.
- D. show that merchant courts avoided all attempts to stabilize commercial rules.
- E. be less informative than records from modern bureaucratic courts in every respect.

rc-006. Select the sentence that most directly identifies a possible bias in the surviving evidence.

- A. Historians of commerce once portrayed early merchant courts as practical institutions that simply applied shared customs.
- B. Recent work has complicated that portrait.
- C. Court records show merchants invoking custom, but they also reveal disputes over what the custom required and strategic efforts to present novel practices as ancient usage.
- D. Written judgments, moreover, often appeared only after litigants pressed for them, so the surviving archive may overrepresent conflicts in which rules were already unsettled.
- E. The courts were therefore neither informal markets for compromise nor modern bureaucracies enforcing a fixed code.
- F. They were arenas in which commercial norms were asserted, contested, and gradually stabilized.

Passage 3

Single-cell RNA sequencing has encouraged biologists to classify tissue samples into ever finer cell types. Yet a cluster in such data is not automatically a biological kind. Cells captured at different moments in a continuous process can appear as separate groups, while stressed

cells may cluster together because the preparation procedure altered their transcription. Conversely, a real functional difference may disappear if the genes that mark it are expressed only briefly. For this reason, many researchers pair clustering algorithms with lineage tracing, protein assays, and experiments that perturb candidate pathways. The aim is not to abandon computational classification, but to prevent the convenience of discrete categories from being mistaken for proof that nature is organized discretely.

rc-007. The passage is primarily concerned with

- A. arguing that single-cell RNA sequencing should be replaced by protein assays.
- B. explaining why computational clusters require biological validation before being treated as cell types.
- C. showing that preparation procedures always prevent accurate tissue classification.
- D. describing how lineage tracing has made clustering algorithms obsolete.
- E. criticizing biologists for ignoring continuous processes in all tissue samples.

rc-008. The reference to stressed cells primarily serves to

- A. give an example of how an apparent cluster may result from the experimental process rather than from a stable biological type.
- B. show that stressed cells are the most important cell type in tissue samples.
- C. identify the main reason protein assays are less reliable than sequencing.
- D. argue that transcriptional data cannot reveal any biological differences.
- E. explain why real functional differences are always temporary.

rc-009. Which of the following considerations support the passage's caution about treating clusters as biological kinds? Select all that apply.

- A. Cells in different phases of one continuous process may appear as separate groups.
- B. Preparation procedures may alter cells in ways that affect clustering.
- C. Every computational cluster corresponds to a stable and discrete functional type.

Passage 4

Dance historians trying to reconstruct early stage works often rely on notation systems that record steps, facings, and floor patterns. Such documents are indispensable, but they preserve only part of a performance. They rarely specify the weight of a gesture, the timing of a hesitation, or the rapport between performers that made a sequence intelligible to audiences. Films and reviews can fill some gaps, though each introduces its own distortions: cameras choose angles, and reviewers may emphasize novelty over routine. A reconstruction is strongest, then, when it presents movement scores, visual records, and contemporary commentary as mutually limiting evidence. Fidelity in this field is less a matter of reproducing every recorded step than of explaining why one plausible performance has been chosen over others.

rc-010. Which of the following best captures the passage's main point?

- A. Dance notation systems are too incomplete to be useful in reconstructing early stage works.
- B. Reliable dance reconstruction requires combining incomplete sources and acknowledging interpretive choices.
- C. Films are usually more faithful records of performance than notation systems or reviews.
- D. Historians should reconstruct only those performances whose original audiences described them in detail.
- E. The goal of reconstruction is to reproduce every recorded step as literally as possible.

rc-011. The passage suggests that a reconstruction based only on notation would be vulnerable because notation generally

- A. records only audience reactions and omits the sequence of movements.
- B. preserves some formal features of movement while leaving out expressive and relational aspects of performance.
- C. distorts a performance by choosing camera angles.
- D. overemphasizes novelty because it is written after the performance.
- E. prevents historians from identifying any plausible version of a work.

rc-012. Select the sentence that most directly states the passage's standard for a strong reconstruction.

- A. Dance historians trying to reconstruct early stage works often rely on notation systems that record steps, facings, and floor patterns.
- B. Such documents are indispensable, but they preserve only part of a performance.
- C. They rarely specify the weight of a gesture, the timing of a hesitation, or the rapport between performers that made a sequence intelligible to audiences.
- D. Films and reviews can fill some gaps, though each introduces its own distortions: cameras choose angles, and reviewers may emphasize novelty over routine.
- E. A reconstruction is strongest, then, when it presents movement scores, visual records, and contemporary commentary as mutually limiting evidence.
- F. Fidelity in this field is less a matter of reproducing every recorded step than of explaining why one plausible performance has been chosen over others.

Passage 5

Companies often treat average customer ratings as direct measures of service quality, but the averages can conceal different problems. A hotel whose guests mostly give moderate scores may need broad operational improvement; one with many excellent ratings and a small number of very low ratings may have a few recurring failures that are hidden by the mean. The timing of requests for feedback also matters: surveys sent immediately after checkout tend to capture memorable inconveniences, whereas surveys sent weeks later may reflect a more general impression. Analysts who study these data therefore recommend examining distributions, comments, and sampling procedures before drawing managerial conclusions. A rating is informative, but only after one asks what experiences were likely to produce it.

rc-013. The passage is primarily concerned with

- A. arguing that customer ratings should be ignored because guests rarely report service problems accurately.
- B. explaining why average ratings require contextual analysis before being used to evaluate service quality.
- C. showing that hotels with many excellent ratings usually have worse service than hotels with moderate ratings.
- D. recommending that companies delay all feedback requests until weeks after a service encounter.
- E. claiming that written comments are objective measures while numerical ratings are subjective ones.

rc-014. According to the passage, two hotels with the same average rating might require different managerial responses because

- A. one average may reflect many similar experiences, while another may mask a pattern of

extreme negative experiences.

B. all ratings collected immediately after checkout are less accurate than ratings collected weeks later.

C. guests who give excellent ratings never mention recurring service failures.

D. a hotel's average rating is determined only by the number of comments submitted.

E. sampling procedures matter less than whether a company publishes its ratings.

rc-015. Which of the following would the analysts mentioned in the passage likely recommend examining before drawing conclusions from average ratings? Select all that apply.

A. The distribution of individual ratings.

B. Written comments accompanying the ratings.

C. The procedure used to sample or solicit responses.

Text Completion

tc-001. The grant proposal was ostensibly interdisciplinary, but its treatment of neighboring fields was so [blank_1] that specialists complained their work had been reduced to decorative citations.

Blank 1

A. perfunctory

B. integrative

C. exhaustive

D. prophetic

E. conciliatory

tc-002. Because the city publishes raw budget data without definitions, the dashboard can appear [blank_1]: it looks transparent while leaving nonspecialists unsure what the categories mean.

Blank 1

A. opaque

B. frugal

C. redundant

D. meticulous

E. permissive

tc-003. The critic's objection was not that the novel was too experimental, but that its experiments were [blank_1], serving no discernible purpose in the plot.

Blank 1

A. innovative

B. gratuitous

C. restrained

D. inevitable

E. lucid

tc-004. The mayor praised the pilot program as (i) [blank_1], but the report's missing control group made its apparent success (ii) [blank_2].

Blank 1

A. promising

- B. obsolete
- C. inconspicuous

Blank 2

- D. difficult to interpret
- E. above reproach
- F. irrelevant

tc-005. Because the poet's revisions removed every local reference, readers found the final version less (i) [blank_1] than the draft, though its general themes became more (ii) [blank_2].

Blank 1

- A. particularized
- B. evasive
- C. doctrinaire

Blank 2

- D. universal
- E. cryptic
- F. provincial

tc-006. The consultant claimed to (i) [blank_1] the museum's mission, yet her plan narrowed exhibits to blockbuster shows, a proposal trustees saw as (ii) [blank_2] rather than expansive.

Blank 1

- A. broaden
- B. codify
- C. archive

Blank 2

- D. constrictive
- E. balanced
- F. philanthropic

tc-007. The committee's minutes have been cited as (i) [blank_1] evidence that members opposed the merger, but the document is more (ii) [blank_2]: it records hesitation about the timetable, not rejection of the deal. To treat it as decisive is therefore to (iii) [blank_3] a procedural worry into a substantive veto.

Blank 1

- A. unequivocal
- B. incidental
- C. fabricated

Blank 2

- D. equivocal
- E. redundant
- F. unanimous

Blank 3

- G. inflate
- H. translate
- I. dissolve

tc-008. The philosopher's reputation for (i) [blank_1] is puzzling, since her published work

repeatedly (ii) [blank_2] final answers and instead traces how each proposed solution generates new questions. Her method is rigorous, but hardly (iii) [blank_3].

Blank 1

- A. dogmatism
- B. levity
- C. erudition

Blank 2

- D. resists
- E. supplies
- F. obscures

Blank 3

- G. doctrinaire
- H. systematic
- I. digressive

tc-009. The archive seemed at first to (i) [blank_1] the official account, since several letters repeated its central claim; closer inspection, however, showed that those letters all derived from a single circular, making the apparent corroboration (ii) [blank_2] and the account's evidentiary basis (iii) [blank_3].

Blank 1

- A. corroborate
- B. complicate
- C. ignore

Blank 2

- D. illusory
- E. independent
- F. cumulative

Blank 3

- G. fragile
- H. abundant
- I. irrelevant

Sentence Equivalence

se-001. The panelist's reply was [blank_1], answering the procedural objection without addressing the ethical challenge that had prompted it.

- A. forthright
- B. evasive
- C. exhaustive
- D. oblique
- E. conciliatory
- F. explicit

se-002. Because the new taxonomy renamed familiar categories without changing the criteria for membership, many researchers regarded it as [blank_1].

- A. rigorous
- B. cosmetic
- C. provisional

- D. superficial
- E. exhaustive
- F. contentious

se-003. The article's tone is [blank_1], granting the opposing study several strengths before identifying the assumption that limits its conclusion.

- A. dismissive
- B. measured
- C. balanced
- D. caustic
- E. indifferent
- F. hostile

se-004. The foundation's annual report was [blank_1]: it announced rising donations but omitted the one-time bequest that made the increase possible.

- A. comprehensive
- B. misleading
- C. laconic
- D. deceptive
- E. celebratory
- F. meticulous

se-005. The professor was not [blank_1] about the theory; even in lectures defending it, she cataloged the evidence that might overturn it.

- A. skeptical
- B. doctrinaire
- C. dogmatic
- D. cautious
- E. indifferent
- F. tentative

se-006. The committee's final report was [blank_1], stitching together incompatible recommendations in order to avoid alienating any faction.

- A. conciliatory
- B. incoherent
- C. decisive
- D. inconsistent
- E. unanimous
- F. meticulous

Answer Key and Explanations

rc-001 - Correct: B

The passage presents leaf-wax analysis as valuable but not self-sufficient, emphasizing alternative explanations and the need for independent evidence. A and E are too negative, while C and D overstate the role of other evidence.

rc-002 - Correct: D

The passage repeatedly warns that a shift in isotope ratios has multiple possible causes and is persuasive only with corroboration. D makes the kind of isolated, conclusive claim the researchers would reject.

rc-003 - Correct: A, B, C

The passage explicitly lists changes in precipitation, changes in plant sources, and increases in reworked sediments as possible explanations for isotope shifts. All three choices are supported.

rc-004 - Correct: C

The passage argues that courts were not merely applying fixed customs; they were places where norms were asserted, contested, and stabilized. A and D make the rules too fixed, B dismisses the records too strongly, and E overstates novelty.

rc-005 - Correct: A

The passage says written judgments often appeared after litigants requested them and may overrepresent conflicts involving unsettled rules. A captures that sampling concern; the other choices are unsupported or contradicted.

rc-006 - Correct: D

Sentence D explicitly explains why the surviving archive may overrepresent a certain kind of case. The other sentences state the prior view, the revised view, evidence of dispute, or the passage's conclusion.

rc-007 - Correct: B

The passage warns that clusters are not automatically biological kinds and recommends validating them with other methods. A and D replace rather than supplement computational classification, while C and E overgeneralize.

rc-008 - Correct: A

The stressed-cell example illustrates an artifact: preparation can alter transcription and make cells cluster together. The passage does not claim that stressed cells are especially important or that sequencing is useless.

rc-009 - Correct: A, B

A and B are both reasons the passage gives for caution. C states the assumption the passage warns against, so it is not supported.

rc-010 - Correct: B

The passage treats notation as indispensable but partial, and it argues for combining sources while explaining interpretive decisions. A rejects notation too strongly, C privileges film

without support, and E reverses the final sentence.

rc-011 - Correct: B

Notation records steps and patterns but rarely captures gesture weight, hesitation, or performer rapport. C describes film, D describes reviews, and A and E contradict the passage's account of notation's usefulness.

rc-012 - Correct: E

Sentence E explicitly identifies when a reconstruction is strongest. Sentence F further explains fidelity, but E most directly states the standard asked for in the stem.

rc-013 - Correct: B

The passage does not reject ratings; it argues that averages can conceal patterns and must be interpreted with distributions, comments, and sampling procedures. B captures this qualified position.

rc-014 - Correct: A

The passage contrasts moderate scores spread broadly with excellent ratings mixed with a few very low ratings that may reveal recurring failures. A captures why equal averages can call for different responses.

rc-015 - Correct: A, B, C

The passage explicitly says analysts recommend examining distributions, comments, and sampling procedures before drawing managerial conclusions. All three choices are supported.

tc-001 - Correct: Blank 1: A

The specialists' complaint indicates that the proposal handled neighboring fields superficially, so perfunctory fits. Integrative and exhaustive would support the interdisciplinary claim rather than undercut it.

tc-002 - Correct: Blank 1: A

The dashboard appears transparent but leaves users unsure, so it is effectively opaque. The other choices do not capture the mismatch between apparent openness and actual comprehensibility.

tc-003 - Correct: Blank 1: B

The objection is that the experiments lack narrative purpose, making them gratuitous. Innovative is tempting because the sentence mentions experimentation, but the criticism concerns function, not novelty.

tc-004 - Correct: Blank 1: A; Blank 2: D

The mayor's praise implies the program looked promising, but a missing control group makes the evidence hard to interpret. Above reproach contradicts the methodological flaw, and irrelevant overstates the problem.

tc-005 - Correct: Blank 1: A; Blank 2: D

Removing local references would make the poem less particularized but more universal. Provincial would move in the opposite direction, and cryptic is not implied by generality.

tc-006 - Correct: Blank 1: A; Blank 2: D

The 'claimed...yet' structure contrasts a promise to broaden the mission with a plan that trustees saw as narrowing it. Constrictive captures their objection; balanced and philanthropic are unsupported.

tc-007 - Correct: Blank 1: A; Blank 2: D; Blank 3: G

The minutes have been treated as decisive opposition, but they only show hesitation about timing. Thus the cited evidence is supposedly unequivocal, actually equivocal, and the error is to inflate a procedural worry into a veto.

tc-008 - Correct: Blank 1: A; Blank 2: D; Blank 3: G

A reputation for dogmatism is puzzling if the work resists final answers. The final clause says the method is rigorous but not doctrinaire. Systematic fits rigorous rather than the contrast, and digressive is unsupported.

tc-009 - Correct: Blank 1: A; Blank 2: D; Blank 3: G

Multiple letters initially appear to corroborate the account, but their shared source means the support is illusory and the evidence remains fragile. Independent and cumulative would be true only if the letters had separate origins.

se-001 - Correct: Blank 1: B, D

Answering a narrower procedural objection while avoiding the ethical issue makes the reply evasive or oblique. Forthright and explicit form a tempting favorable pair but conflict with the avoidance described.

se-002 - Correct: Blank 1: B, D

Renaming categories without changing the underlying criteria is merely cosmetic or superficial. Rigorous and exhaustive imply substantive value, while provisional and contentious are not established by the sentence.

se-003 - Correct: Blank 1: B, C

Acknowledging strengths before criticizing a limiting assumption indicates a measured or balanced tone. Dismissive, caustic, and hostile overstate the criticism; indifferent ignores the careful evaluation.

se-004 - Correct: Blank 1: B, D

The report's omission of the one-time bequest makes its claim about rising donations misleading or deceptive. Celebratory may describe its tone but not the effect of the omission, and comprehensive and meticulous contradict it.

se-005 - Correct: Blank 1: B, C

A defender who carefully lists evidence that could overturn the theory is not rigidly committed to it, so not doctrinaire and not dogmatic fit. Skeptical, cautious, and tentative are tempting but describe qualities her behavior actually suggests.

se-006 - Correct: Blank 1: B, D

A report made by stitching together incompatible recommendations is incoherent or inconsistent. Conciliatory explains the motive but not the resulting logical problem; unanimous and meticulous are unsupported.